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STARTUPS



**A top designer was
banned from Dribbble.
Now he's building his
own competitor.**

[Dribbble](#) has permanently banned dozens of designers from its platform following a new effort to pivot to a marketplace and chase monetization. This includes one of the platform's most well-known designers, [Gleb Kuznetsov, founder of the San Francisco-based design studio Milkinside](#).

Dribbble deleted his account with its [over 210 million](#) followers because he shared his contact information with prospective clients through the platform in violation of its new rules.

Remarked Kuznetsov [in a post on X](#), "I brought 100,000+ monthly users. 15 years of work. 12,000+ shots. All instantly deleted, because a client asked for my email. One warning. No appeal."

Fed up with the changes at the company, which helps product, UX, web, and other digital designers showcase their portfolios and find new clients, Kuznetsov says he's been talking to investors about launching a competitor.

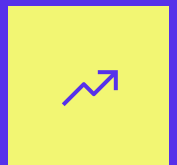
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Gleb Kuznetsov

@glebich · Follow



Totally agree with [@jondschubert](#) . I loved [@dribbble](#). I brought 100,000+ monthly users. 15 years of work. 12,000+ shots.

All instantly deleted, because a client asked for my email. One warning. No appeal.

They didn't care about the community. Just their 3% cut.

Dribbble is [Show more](#)

RIP *Dribbble*

THIS PLATFORM MADE MY FREELANCE CAREER POSSIBLE;
I'VE BEEN A DRIBBBLE MEMBER SINCE 2011.

IN 2025 DRIBBBLE HAS DECIDED THAT RATHER THAN SIMPLY FACILITATE COMMUNITY AND A PLATFORM FOR CREATIVE WORK IT WOULD ALSO LIKE TO ACT AS A DEFACTO MANAGING AGENCY BY INSERTING ITSELF BETWEEN DESIGNERS AND PROSPECTIVE CLIENTS, AND LORDING OVER ANY AND ALL CONNECTIONS WHICH ARE MADE ON THE SITE. DRIBBBLE WILL NOT ALLOW THE SHARING OF BASIC INFORMATION BETWEEN ENTITIES USING (AND PAYING FOR IN SOME CASES) ITS PLATFORM WHICH WOULD ALLOW EACH PARTY AN ARRAY OF OPTIONS FOR PURSUING COLLABORATION AND CONNECTION OUTSIDE OF DRIBBBLE. I APPRECIATE WHAT DRIBBBLE HAS BEEN GOOD FOR IN THE DISTANT PAST...BUT I DIDN'T SIGN UP FOR WHAT IT HAS EVOLVED INTO IN 2025. RIP DRIBBBLE, THANKS FOR RUINING IT.

Last edited 8:02 PM · Jul 29, 2025



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Shortly after his social media post, Dribbble users expressed their shock and anger over the decision, crediting Kuznetsov as being one of their biggest inspirations and lamenting that the platform would make such a misguided move.

Dribbble, meanwhile, says Kuznetsov was actually warned multiple times that he was violating the new rules and the email was the final notice.

Dribbble's pivot to a marketplace

The issue has to do with a more recent policy change first announced on March 17, 2025.



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In an email shared in March with Dribbble's some 750,000 approved designers — meaning those who are authorized to communicate with others on the platform — the company said it was no longer allowing designers to share their contact information with prospective clients until after their client sent payment through its platform.

The company positioned this change as one meant to protect designers from non-payment, as well as one that allows Dribbble to continue to sustain its business.

The announcement was also posted to social media and the [company blog](#).



Hi [User],

We want to inform you of an important change to our [Terms of Service](#).

What's changing?

Starting today, Dribbble designers and clients who meet on Dribbble must keep payments on Dribbble. This means designers are no longer permitted to display or share their contact information (like email addresses, phone numbers, social media handles) *prior to client payment on Dribbble*. **After payment, designers and clients are able to exchange contact information.**

Why the change?

Designers can now receive requests, send proposals, deliver work, and get paid, entirely through Dribbble. When clients pay designers through Dribbble, we can protect both parties and mediate any issues that arise during the course of the project. We can also invest more in our product, marketing, and support, which will create more opportunities for designers.

By completing projects on Dribbble, designers:

- Avoid scams and late payment or nonpayment.
- Rank higher in search results and generate more leads.
- Enable us to commit more resources towards feature development and lead generation.

What do I need to do?

If your contact details are displayed on Dribbble, you will receive a separate email with more information (don't worry, we can make the necessary updates on your behalf). If you don't hear from us, you're already in compliance with the new policy.

As always, we are here to help you be successful on Dribbble. If you have questions about the policy, [check out our FAQ](#) or reach out to us [here](#).

Thanks for being part of the community.

The Dribbble Team

You received this email because you have a Dribbble account, and this is a required notification of an update to our Terms of Service. This message is essential and sent regardless of your email preferences.

Dribbble Holdings, LTD.
524 Yates St • Victoria CA • V8W 1K8

IMAGE CREDITS:DRIBBBLE

However, Kuznetsov claims that non-payment isn't a very common problem, and really, this update is about Dribbble attempting to take a larger cut of designers' business.

Dribbble doesn't dispute that.

Before the policy change, Dribbble made money in one of two ways. Starting in September 2024, Dribbble began pivoting to a marketplace that connected designers and clients. Designers could communicate freely on the platform and then either share a 3.5% revenue cut on clients they converted, or they could pay for [a Pro subscription](#) to skip the rev share. In March, the company tightened the rules further, saying that anyone finding clients on Dribbble would need to offer the platform a cut of their revenue.

“It went from it was optional to use our transactional features to it was required for non-advertisers to use our transactional features, if they were on Dribbble, to find clients,” explains [Dribbble CEO Constantine Anastasakis](#), in an interview with TechCrunch. “If a user is on Dribbble to find inspiration or to get feedback on their work, or to talk shop with their peers, none of this affects them,” he added.

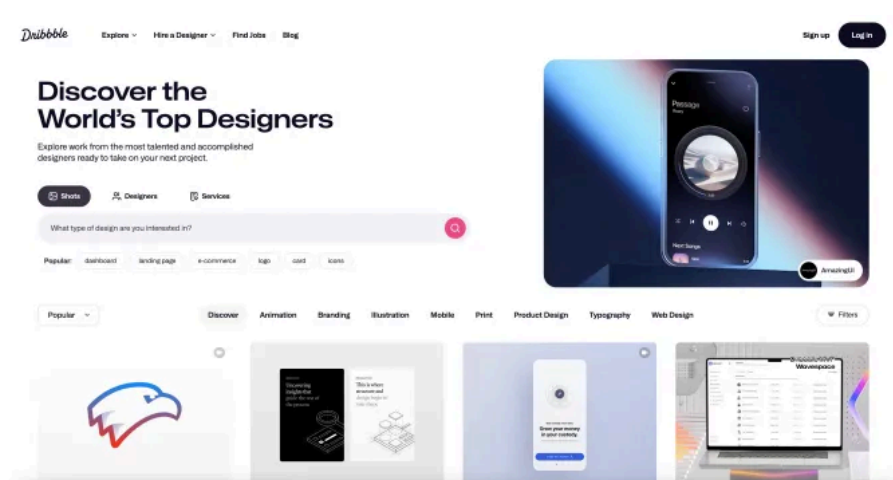


IMAGE CREDITS:DRIBBBLE

The exec, who joined the company after working at direct-to-consumer lender Lower, video marketplace Pond5 (exited to Shutterstock), and freelancer marketplace Fiverr, was hired last April to pivot Dribbble into a marketplace. While the company is profitable under parent company [Tiny](#), it’s still a small 20-person team and isn’t reliant on venture backing to serve its 7.5 to 10 million monthly unique visitors.

“Dribbble was something that really accelerated our business dramatically back in the day,” Kuznetsov told TechCrunch. Before Dribbble, there was no platform where designers could share their work with others, he says. It helped designers receive feedback that came specifically from their peers and allowed newer designers to learn from those at the top of the industry.

Kuznetsov is now part of the latter group.

At Milkinside, Kuznetsov has worked with companies like Apple, Google, Amazon, Scandinavian Airlines, United Airlines, Honda, Mitsubishi, Mercedes-Benz, and other large companies in the Bay Area.

As a result, he likely didn't feel that Dribbble would risk banning him for not abiding by the new terms.

Anastasakis essentially confirmed this to be true.

He told TechCrunch that Kuznetsov received 83 work inquiries since the new terms rolled out in March, and responded to 61. In each message, the site shows a warning that reminds users that contact details should not be shared before project payment. However, Kuznetsov shared his contact information in six messages, which would have displayed a stronger warning at that time.



IMAGE CREDITS:DRIBBBLE

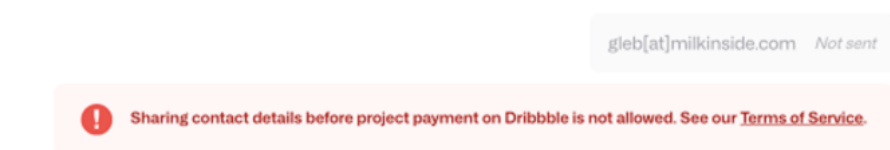


IMAGE CREDITS:DRIBBBLE

The company then followed up with a warning email on July 22 about his repeated terms-of-service violations, which informed him he was risking permanent suspension.

Kuznetsov told us he didn't see this email initially, but Dribbble says it tracked that the email was opened three times before his suspension.

"I believe that Dribbble — it was their goal to hurt me so I can spread that [news] so they can give a

harsh lesson to everyone who tries [to break the rules],” Kuznetsov says.

Anastasakis confirmed as much to TechCrunch.

“There’s really no conceivable way in which he did not realize that what he was doing risked permanent suspension of his accounts,” Anastasakis told us.

“I think that ultimately it was that he believed that we wouldn’t take action against a designer of his caliber,” he continued. “As a side note, I actually think that he’s done us a big favor as far as getting the word out about how seriously we take the terms.”

For Kuznetsov, or any designer who was banned for similar reasons, the only option to come back to Dribbble is by joining as an advertiser, which requires a minimum campaign budget of \$1,500 per month for at least three months.

A new competitor to Dribbble emerges?

Kuznetsov has decided to forge his own path, saying that he’s hurt by Dribbble’s change.

“It’s not going to be a copycat of Dribbble,” he says of his pending startup. Instead, it will be a resource for designers that will also leverage AI.

While there has been a lot of backlash about AI models training on creatives’ work without compensation, Kuznetsov believes there’s a use case for the technology in terms of inspiration, creation, and design.



IMAGE CREDITS:GLEB KUZNETSOV

“It’s a big hole right now in the market ... Everybody’s doing AI startups, but nobody’s really doing AI startups for designers,” Kuznetsov notes. “AI is something that really can elevate our ability to create, and make it on a much higher level of quality. It’s going to help us to not only earn more money and grow, but also create something we never even thought was possible to create without a specific skill set.”

Kuznetsov says he expects to have an [MVP](#) (minimum viable product) ready in three or four

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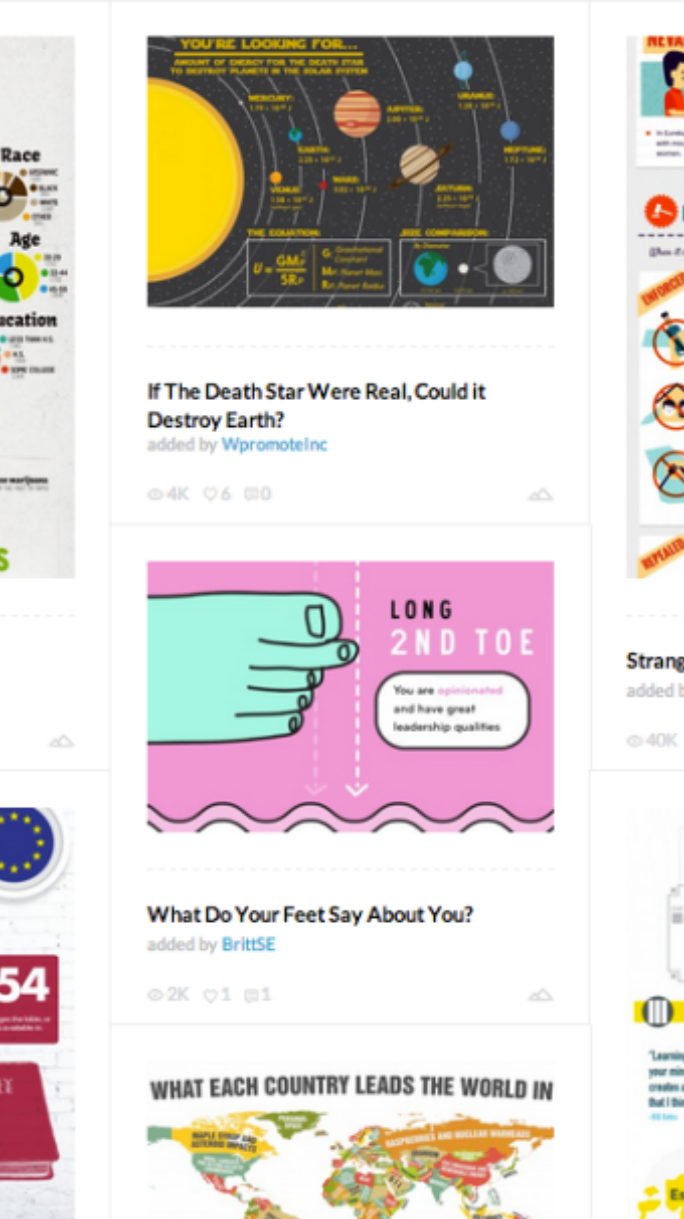
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Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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Visually, The Infographics Marketplace, Launches Its New Cloud-Based Collaborative Project Center

Catherine Shu — 7:07 AM PDT · October 29, 2013

[Visually](#), best known as a marketplace for infographics, has launched its new Marketplace and Project Center to grow the audience for its cloud-based collaborative tools. Customers can now use the marketplace to create videos, presentations, interactive graphics, infographics and other visual content.

The San Francisco-based startup says there are currently 100,000 creative professionals on the platform and that Visually has paid out nearly \$2 million in project fees. Visually gives designers a way to reach clients ranging from startups to Fortune 1000 companies. The company says that of the designers that apply to be on Visually, only 10% meet its quality standards.

[Founded in 2011 by Stewart Langille and Lee Sherman](#), the team behind Mint.com's graphics, Visually seeks to change the traditional agency model of content creation. For clients, who have included AOL, Nike, Twitter, NBC, P&G, UNESCO, The Atlantic, Visa, Verizon and Dell, the benefits of using Visually include fixed costs, lower risk, satisfaction guarantees, faster completion rates (sometimes within 24 hours) and access to a wider range of designers. For creative professionals, Visually gives them the chance to work with high profile companies, gain wider exposure for their work and belong to an online community similar to [Dribbble](#) or [Forrst](#).

"Our customers love the experience they get on Visually—the diverse pool of creative talent, the ease of collaboration, and the speed to market. This launch allows us to provide a comprehensive solution for our customers—a one stop shop for all of their visual content," said Langille in a statement.

Topics: [marketplace](#) [Startups](#) [Visually](#)

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Catherine Shu

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Catherine Shu covered startups in Asia and breaking news for TechCrunch. Her reporting has also appeared in the...

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Dribbble, Share Your Designs And Get Feedback In Realtime

Alexia Tsotsis

1:24 PM PDT · August 9, 2010

dribbble Etiquette

• HINT no. 1 •

Provide feedback only
when asked.

(you pompous ass)

[Dribbble](#), yes that's three Bs, is a platform that allows you to share 400 by 300 sneak peeks on design projects ("shots") in realtime, with a community of like-minded designers, developers and other creatives giving you [feedback](#) on your work.

Co-founded by Dan Cederholm and Rich Thornett, the Salem, Massachusetts-based Dribbble launched its alpha in April but is still relatively on the down low, since membership is invitation only. The invites ("drafts") to become a Dribbble "player" have become [a much coveted thing](#). From Cederholm, *"We've been careful in giving out invitations, doing so in small, infrequent batches. That helps quality (the player drafts wisely) and helps scaling as well (we're two guys bootstrapping this ourselves)."*

Dribbble currently has over 4,000 players and despite or perhaps due to this exclusivity the community is vibrant, spawning many of its own memes including the infamous ["hate" button](#). While design portfolio sites like [Coroflot](#) are nothing new, Dribbble's social functionality and active community set it apart. Fortunately for the rest of us, everything on Dribbble is publicly viewable and the only difference between a player and a Dribbble member is the ability to upload designs, comment and follow people.

Dribbble recently released [its API](#) and has been flooded with a slew of clients most notably [Dunk](#), an

iPhone app and [Dribbble](#), and iPad app set to hit the app store any day. Designer [Jason Lynes](#) recently devoted a snapshot to Dribbble etiquette, and there's even an entire blog [covering new apps](#).

In terms of future plans for Cederholm and Thornett, there are a lot, and even a few they can talk about.

"We're looking into ways of making it easier to get great talent into Dribbble while still supporting an invitation system that helps us scale gracefully—and potentially to allow non-designers to follow Dribbble players with non-uploading accounts."

In other words, they're growing. Dribbble will be closing in on its 4 billionth pixel uploaded shortly. What other social network has those kind of bragging rights?



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Dribbble invitation wanted

by Magnus Cederholm

August 08, 2010

400 x 300

102 views



5 Likes

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retro

typography

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Magnus Cederholm

I have wanted a dribbble invite for a long time, and finally I got one!

This badge was suppose to be on the header on my new portfolio (coming out soon), but I guess I have to take it away now since I'm already here. Thanks for the invite, Sandro :)

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Robin Raszka

Prague, Czech Republic

tapmates.com

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51 FOLLOWING

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1 DRAFTEE



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21

56

Robin Raszka



1327

10

33

Robin Raszka



4872

43

173

Robin Raszka



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Alexia Tsotsis

Alexia Tsotsis is a big nerd who is working on something under the radar. Before this she was at business school...

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